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‘Relocate Kundrathur BDO from Padappai’

P. SENTHIL KUMAR

The Kundrathur Block Development Office of Rural Development & Panchayat Raj Department is located in Padappai which is at one end of Kundrathur BDO's limits.

Padappai is near the border of Wallajahbad which by itself is another Block Development Office.

It will be convenient for the public if Kundrathur BDO is relocated to Kundrathur, a location central to the 42 Village Panchayats it serves.

It is a quite a distance away (30 km) for the Kundrathur BDO's Village Panchayats situated in the west which includes Iyyppanthangal, Bharaniputhur, Mouliwakkam, Kovur, and Mangadu.

Further, Kundrathur BDO is also 20 km away from the Kundrathur Taluk Office of the Revenue



Kundrathur Block Development Office in Padappai. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Department.

Generally, a Block Development Office and Taluk Office are located nearby. It is assumed that considering the functions of both the departments, these offices are locat-

ed nearby though they come under two different departments.

The key functions of a Taluk Office include maintaining land records, conducting land surveys, collecting land revenue, updating

property records upon ownership changes, issuing certificates (income, caste, and residence), monitoring public distribution systems, and acting as an Executive Magistrate to maintain law and order.

And a BDO is responsible for implementing government welfare schemes, acts as the vital link between district administration and village-level governance, managing funds, and implementing rural infrastructure projects.

The common public approaches a BDO office seeking permission for building construction and to give petitions seeking civic facilities such as roads, street lights, and water supply.

But in the case of Kundrathur, both these offices are quite far. Further, the Metropolitan Transport Corporation does not operate any direct bus service connecting these two offices.

Considering the convenience of the public, the Kundrathur Block Development Office should be shifted from Padappai to Kundrathur.

P. Senthil Kumar is a resident of Iyyppanthangal

‘Footpath in school zone usurped’



Footpath in Valasarawakkam on Arcot Road. The image was taken on February 27, 2026. PHOTO: VELANKANNI RAJ B

VENKATASUBRAMANIAM .D

The image shows an unfriendly footpath on a section of Arcot Road in Valasarawakkam. It is overrun with encroachments. It may be noted there is a school in the vicinity.

Arcot Road is a narrow and the ongoing metro rail construction has further narrowed it. This road witness heavy traffic and pedestrians are in peril.

Venkatasubramaniam .D is a resident of Vadapalani



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Student of SRM Vadapalani selected as Google Ambassdor

Ramprakash R. is among only six students in India to be given this title and an opportunity to meet Google CEO Sundar Pichai

Ramprakash R., a final year B.Tech CSE (AIML) student from the Department of Computer Science and Engineering (Emerging Technologies), SRM Institute of Science and Technology in Vadapalani, has earned national recognition as one of six Google Student Ambassadors across India.

According to a press release, Ramprakash received the extraordinary opportunity to directly interact with Sundar Pichai, CEO of Google, during the India AI Impact Summit 2026 held on February 18, 2026 at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi.

At the summit, he contributed

to discussions on Responsible and Inclusive AI, bridging academia and industry, and empowering engineering students through applied AI. The achievement highlights his technical excellence and brings pride and national recognition to SRM IST, the release adds.



During the event. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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‘One-way traffic move on Rukmani Lakshmipathy Salai futile’

The exercise was aimed at decongesting the Pantheon Road Roundabout during rush hour; but it has succeeded only in transferring the problem to Red Cross Road and Pantheon Road

K. VASANTHA

With the aim of decongesting Pantheon Road roundabout in Egmore, a section of Rukmani Lakshmipathy Salai (formerly known as Marshall's Road) was made one-way this January.

The stretch of the road from Pantheon Road roundabout to Red Cross Road (earlier known as Montieth Road) junction is one-way during peak hours, that is from nine to eleven in the morning and from five to eight in the evening.

But regular users find the move has not yielded the desired result as Pantheon Road roundabout continues to be chaotic.

Instead, it has resulted in traffic congestion at the nearby roads – Red Cross Road and Pantheon Road. A line of vehicles can be seen waiting in a long queue in these two roads when Rukmani Lakshmipathy Salai goes into one-way traffic mode. Both these roads are narrow and there is no way to



Pantheon Road and (above) entrance to Rukmani Lakshmipathy Salai blocked at the junction of Red Cross Road. PHOTOS: RAGU .R & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

overtake a vehicle and hence traffic moves at a slow pace during the rush hour.

One of the trying spots is near government maternity hospital on Pantheon Road. When a bus halts



at the stop near the hospital, there is no way to overtake any vehicle.

Parking of vehicles on both sides of the road add to the problem on Red Cross Road.

Residential buildings are also located on the one-way section of the road; and it is meaningless for local residents to have to take a detour while having to go to a nearby street.

Further, patients visiting the government eye hospital on Rukmani Lakshmipathy Salai also find this arrangement inconvenient as they have to take a detour to enter and exit the road.

Traffic police also find this arrangement challenging. Traffic police personnel are deployed at four spots on the one-way section of Rukmani Lakshmipathy Salai: near Pantheon roundabout, near Driver Street intersection, near Monteith Lane intersection; and near Red Cross Road junction.

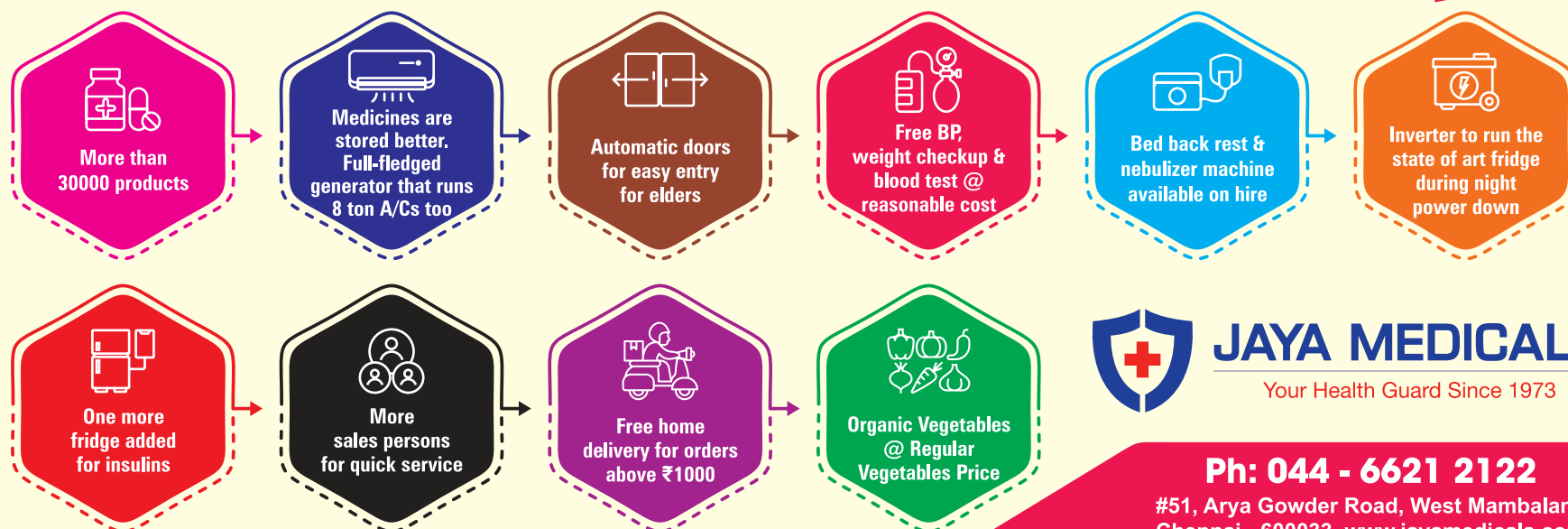
The authorities concerned should revisit the traffic plan as it does not serve the purpose for which it was introduced.

K. Vasantha is a resident of Egmore

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On the bench at Conran Smith Road

A close look at the offbeat benches and garbage bins that line one side of this road in Gopalapuram

PRINCE FREDERICK

Flaneurs trying to decode roadside human behaviour, armchair philosophers seeking an alternative to the trite old armchair and pedestrians seeking to give their tired limbs a break would have something going for them if they hit Conran Smith Road in Gopalapuram.

Greater Chennai Corporation has placed benches on one side of the road, spaced apart on the pavement. Each bench finds kindred souls in two garbage bins. It obviously does not share Key Performance Areas with the bins, and what it does share is morphology.

All three are semi-permanent concrete structures; the bins are open-topped; and they are set in a colour schema different from the one defining the bench.

When *The Hindu Downtown* ambled down the pavement to take in these new additions to the road, the benches were occupied, so were the garbage bins. Clearly, a

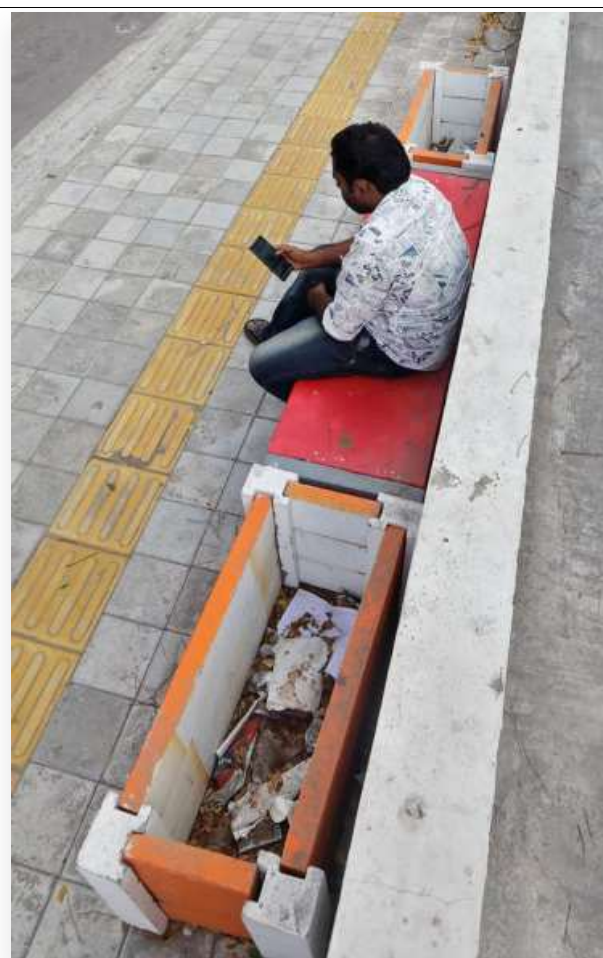


heart-warming sight.

And the fact that these concrete bins are on the pavement and neatly aligned with the bench that they go with, is a relief. With bins making it to the carriageway and getting grouted there, in recent times, road users are now bracing themselves for fresh surprises. When they are spared a surprise, the sigh of relief is almost thunderous.

Steering clear of the carriageway is among the few ameliorating factors; and even collectively, they cannot paper over glaring omissions.

There are no signages on the bins declaring their mandate: what they are supposed to take, wet waste or dry waste. One finds mixed waste in all the bins. The idea behind keeping the bins open



▼ The images were taken on February 27, 2026. PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK

is probably to invite bench users to make use of them, but unwittingly, the invitation is would be extended to the rain chief. These structures are of recent installation and had arrived c after the last NE Monsoon left, so the unsavoury situation has not arisen yet. And there is no internal removable compartment to clear the garbage. The stainless steel bins one finds on carriage-

ways now can be wiped clean easily when soiled, this one cannot if stubborn stains get attached to it. Besides, the wide, open garbage bins are too close to the bench for the sitters' comfort.

Every troika consisting of one bench and two bins is set against the compound wall of an establishment including the compound wall of the Gopalapuram playground.

Residents on 'night duty'

Thuvakkam relaunches 'Clean Up After Dark' with a drive on February 28 at an old age home

LIFFY THOMAS

Chennai-based non-profit Thuvakkam has relaunched its signature initiative 'Clean Up After Dark'. It returned in a refreshed form on February 28 at Anbusolai old age home in Perungudi.

The essence of this drive: resident-volunteers taking to the streets after evenfall, typically after 6 p.m. and making them squeaky clean, the work continuing till the wee hours of the following day.

Thuvakkam ran 'Clean Up After Dark' for close to four years until the pandemic forced it into an extended hibernation. In the pre-pandemic years, the clean-up happened at public spaces including government schools, busy roads and markets, many a time twice a month.

In the Mylapore area, volunteers spruced up bus shelters in Mandaveli, Luz Corner and St Mary's Road by removing posters, clearing the cobwebs

and giving them a fresh coat of paint.

Krishna Kumar Suresh, founder, Thuvakkam, reveals the campaign got this young NGO popular and brought many new volunteers into its fold.

They would combine it with events such as Dhan Utsav to draw volunteers from organisations or neighbourhoods.

In many localities, residents suggested places that needed a clean-up.

"We had painted a government school in KK Nagar, leaving to complete with artworks. The paint has now worn off a bit, not the message," says Krishna.

The relaunched version of this initiative will follow the same pattern. The plan is to take up one activity a month.

Clean-up as such does not require any special skills but just the willingness to listen to the instructions and carry them out on the field during the activity.

Thuvakkam invites resident associations and institutions to suggest places in their locality that needs a clean-up.

For more details, call Dinesh Babu at 97915 19208



Educating the special educators

Over the last week, practitioners from 15 institutions in Chennai went through an in-person upskilling training programme conducted by the faculty of Portobello Institute in Ireland; Chennai Volunteers made this exercise possible



Representational picture only.

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

When Lakshmi Menon and her team members started to solve the 'Zin Monument' activity based on clues given to them, they found it an uphill task. The problem-solving exercise required them to determine the day of the week the monument was completed. They found themselves having to do three things simultaneously: look at the problem keenly; communicate it in the best possible way and collaborate intensely as they went about solving it.

More than 30 special educators like Lakshmi, representing WeCAN, got a ringside view of a variety of problem-solving strategies they could apply in their classroom, thanks to an immersive workshop organised by Chennai Volunteers in partnership with Portobello Institute in Ireland.

'Celebrating Neurodiversity 2.0', as the workshop was called, was aimed at upskilling special educators, therapists, trainers working with children and young people with Autism Spectrum Disorder and related developmental and behavioural challenges.



Rinku Mecheri (extreme left) with the team from Portobello Institute and some of the participants

In a press release, Rinku Mecheri, founder, Chennai Volunteers, says that the programme is a follow-up to last year's initiative, based on an in-depth assessment of the unique needs of special children in underserved communities, in and around Chennai.

The initiative is aimed at strengthening non-profits working in the field of special education so that so they can work more effectively with their students and beneficiaries.

In this certified programme, the content and presentations are shared with all, and each team cascades the knowledge to their colleagues in the respective organisation, says Rinku. This in-person programme would be followed by online sessions.

A team of six faculty led by Denise Flood, Executive Dean of Portobello Institute, conducted

various sessions including one on impact of physical education, creative arts and music therapy in the classroom.

The team from Portobello Institute also visited some of the schools or homes to engage with the students.

Rinku says Chennai Volunteers is proud to host this programme that helps the special needs educators and therapists by building their skills, strengthening inclusion and creating impact.

"Volunteers can bring about transformative change through capacity building and skill training, and we want more individuals and organisations to come forward and benefit," she adds.

One can reach out to Chennai Volunteers at contactus@chennaivolunteers.org or call 9840182299.

'Government support needed to further special education'

LIFFY THOMAS

Denise Flood, Executive Dean at Portobello Institute in Dublin, Ireland, led a six-member team that was in Chennai for a week-long programme for special educators initiated by Chennai Volunteers. In an interaction with *The Hindu Downtown*, Denise talks about the importance of flexible courses in Special Needs Assisting and the role of government in furthering the reach of inclusive education.

* What is the importance of this five-day programme?

Education is evolving globally, particularly in how we support learners with intellectual and developmental disabilities. As our understanding of diverse learning profiles grows, educators must continually update their skills to respond effectively to emerging classroom needs.

This five-day programme provides an opportunity for practitioners to refresh their knowledge, engage with current research and collaborate with peers to develop practical, inclusive strategies. The focus is on empowering educators to create learning environments where children with additional needs can participate fully and thrive alongside their peers.

* Special schools and NGOs in India encourage parents of children with special needs to become special educators. What do you have to say about this trend?

It is encouraging to see schools and centres supporting parents seeking to pursue training in special education. Parents bring invaluable lived experience and insight into their child's strengths and needs.

When equipped with professional training, they can rein-

force learning across home and school environments, supporting language development, social skills and independence in a consistent and meaningful way.

* Portobello Institute offers a number of flexible programmes in Special Needs Assisting, why are such programmes necessary?

Many professionals seek opportunities to upskill while continuing to work, which is why our programmes are designed with flexible delivery options. This accessibility helps broaden participation and strengthens the inclusive education workforce.

There is increasing demand for inclusive practices across all levels of education, beginning in early years settings. Professional training ensures that practition-

Parents bring invaluable lived experience and insight into their child's strengths and needs

ers are equipped with evidence-based approaches, practical skills and the confidence to support diverse learners effectively.

* What can India learn from Dublin?

In Ireland, there has been significant investment in supporting students who wish to pursue qualifications in special education. Government funding models have helped make these programmes more accessible encouraging practitioners to return to education and enhance their qualifications.

We have seen strong engagement in our own programmes, with over 200 practitioners upskilling last academic year reflecting a clear commitment within the sector to continuous professional development.

Even as Wels in Austria hosted World Sustainable Energy Days 2026 from February 24 to 27, *The Hindu Downtown* picked the brains of quiet influencers in Chennai Bhuvana Raj and Saravanan Palanichami whose philosophy of sustainable energy use in their home settings is rubbing off on neighbours and friends

Infectious energy



Saravanan Palanichami and Bhuvana Raj with their respective solar installations. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

There is a pleasant monotony to how Bhuvana Raj's electricity bill reads for most part of the year. For nearly ten months annually, every billing cycle, the needle stays at zero (discounting the small regular fee).

A sustainability practitioner and zero waste consultant, Bhuvana installed a rooftop solar system at her home in Thalambur, off OMR, in 2018, when residential solar adoption in Chennai Metropolitan Area was yet to shine brightly.

Although the initial estimate suggested a 2 kW system would suffice, the family chose to plan ahead. "The estimate given for our house was 2 kW. But we decided to add one more unit, thinking that our consumption would increase in the future and we should be able to offset that as well. So we went in for a 3 kW system in 2018 itself," she says. The system cost about ₹1.5 lakh after subsidy.

"I am not exactly sure when it broke even, but I think it was

around four years after installation," she adds.

Only during peak summer, when air conditioner use increases, does the family pay anything at all. "Only during April and May, when consumption increases because of AC usage, do we pay an amount for consumption." And this amount is still one of ridiculously small numbers.

"Recently, they started charging a network fee of around ₹300 plus, so that is the only regular fee we are paying now," she explains. "Not worrying about electricity bills, especially when others pay ₹10,000 or ₹12,000 during summer, is very reassuring," she says.

Though her overall experience is pleasant, Bhuvana would like to see some wrinkles ironed out, not on her end, but Tangedco's.

"When we generate more energy than we use, it goes back to the grid, but Tangedco does not pay us for that surplus. Besides, there is no dashboard to show how many unused units we are giving back," she says.

She adds that people often have doubts when choosing systems. Off

grid systems use batteries and can function during outages. Systems connected to the grid are more economical but shut down during power cuts for safety reasons. "Our area gets flooded during monsoons, and sometimes power cuts continue for days. In such situations, off grid systems help. But when we did the math, on grid made more sense economically in the long run," she says.

In her gated villa community of around 330 houses, rooftop solar adoption has steadily increased. "Around 30 to 40 per cent have gone solar. We are not actively promoting it, but people are installing it on their own after understanding the benefits" she says.

For Bhuvana, the decision goes beyond savings. "I see solar not just as a cost saving option but also as a responsible choice for the future. In our country, we have abundant sunlight almost throughout the year," she says.

She also believes more attention must be paid to what happens later. "After 20 or 30 years, what happens to these panels? How will they be recycled? These are areas

where more research is needed," she says, adding that policy and research must evolve alongside adoption.

A smart move

A software engineer based in Kovilambakkam, Saravanan Palanichami installed his first solar system 13 years ago, at the time he built his house. "The original idea was to ensure uninterrupted power supply," he says. Instead of depending entirely on an inverter connected to the grid, he chose a 1.4 kilowatt off grid system with batteries that could function like a UPS.

For years, that system powered the essentials – fans, refrigerator, televisions, computers and lights. During the day, solar panels charged the batteries. At night, the stored energy ran the house until early morning. When Cyclone Vardah struck Chennai and power cuts lasted for days, his decision proved wise. "During major storms in Chennai, including Cyclone Vardah, when there were week long power cuts, this system proved extremely useful," he recalls.

But the real turning point came recently, with the purchase of an electric vehicle.

"Recently, we bought an electric vehicle. We realised that if the car had to be truly zero emission, the energy used to charge it should also come from renewable sources," he says. That realisation prompted the installation of an additional 6 kilowatt on grid solar system.

Unlike the battery backed setup, the on grid system operates independently of household wiring. "The on grid system is not connected to any of my appliances, including the EV. It supplies power back to the grid through the power lines," he explains. Through net metering, electricity generated during the day is exported to the grid.

His advice to EV owners: "If you have an on grid system, you are already prepared. Try to charge your EV during the day to maximise the use of your generated power. If you have to charge at night, your solar installation will still reduce your overall electricity cost, but you will not be reducing the load on the grid at that time."

Remembering Subramania Bharati

Shriram Bharathi Kalai Ilakkiya Kazhagam recently observed the 144th birth anniversary of freedom fighter and poet Subramania Bharathi at Krishna Gana Sabha, T. Nagar. Three eminent scholars promoting Bharathi's work across the globe, M. Thyagarajan, K. Laimamani Keezhambur Sankara Subramanian, and V.G. Booma, were felicitated on the occasion with cash awards and citations.

Ku. Gnanasambanthan, emeritus, professor Thiyagarajar College, Madurai, spoke on 'Vetri Mael Vetri'.

Justice R. Suresh Kumar, Madras High Court, released a book, 'Avvaiyin Senthamizh Puthaiyal.'

A copy of the book was distributed to all attendees of the event.

Assistance given to differently abled

Lions International District 324IF distributed groceries to 100 differently-abled persons. According to a press release, a financial assistance of ₹10,000 each was also given to an intellectually-disabled girl and a cerebral palsy affected boy. Also a sum of ₹500 was distributed to 200-differently abled persons.

The event was held at ECI Matriculation Higher Secondary School, Ekkattuthangal.

On the occasion, Beacon of Hope for the Differently-Abled Award was presented to Saisankara Panchapakesan, founder, Chennai Sai Thunai Matrimonils in recognition of his service towards the welfare of the differently-abled in Tamil Nadu for more than 30 years.



Winners of the competition.

Painting equity and unity

SRM marks Zero Discrimination Day with art competition at Ekkattuthangal; the first, second and third prizes were secured by students from Anna University, Madras Christian College and Sri Annai Kamakshi Music and Fine Arts College respectively



The Department of Visual Communication and Faculty of Science and Humanities at SRM Institute of Science and Technology – Vadapalani Campus organised an inter-collegiate painting competition titled HUES 2026 at the Ekkattuthangal campus on February 27 to commemorate Zero Discrimination Day, observed every year on March 1.

According to a press release, the competition was centered on the theme "Democracy Begins with Participation," encouraging young artists to express ideas of equality, inclusivity, and active civic engagement

through art. Twenty-one colleges from in and around Chennai enthusiastically participated, showcasing remarkable creativity and originality, the release adds.

The programme was graced by R. Sasikala, Assistant Director (Design), Weavers Service Centre, Ministry of Textiles, Government of India, as chief guest. With her address, she inspired students to integrate innovation with cultural sensitivity. The entries were judged by eminent artist Alagarraja based on parameters such as originality, creativity, composition, color harmony and relevance to the theme.

The first, second and third prizes were secured by students from Anna University, Madras Christian College and Sri Annai Kamakshi Music and Fine Arts College respectively. HUES 2026 stood as a vibrant celebration of artistic excellence and a meaningful tribute to democratic values and zero discrimination.

Student initiates career guidance programme in Vyasarpadi

Sanju Vikasini D of Madras School of Social Work decided to educate people in the locality about job openings in the government sector



A career guidance programme titled "What Next? Your Path to Government Careers" was organised on February 26 by the PG Department of Social Work (SF), Madras School of Social Work, in collaboration with Oasis India, in Vyasarpadi.

The programme was organised by Sanju Vikasini D, a student of the Post Graduate Department of Social Work (SF), Madras School of Social Work, as part of her fieldwork with Oasis India,

said a release. During her field engagement, she found that many students, unemployed graduates, and youth in the community—particularly those from socially and economically vulnerable backgrounds—lacked access to reliable information and guidance regarding career in the government sector.

The session was facilitated by G. Sriram, Founder and Director of Kalam IAS Academy, who spoke about

the importance of government employment as a means of achieving financial security, dignity, and long-term stability. He provided clarity on career pathways and motivated participants to pursue their goals with determination and confidence.

The programme witnessed enthusiastic participation from nearly 100 members of the Vyasarpadi community, including unemployed graduates and homemakers.

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Job fair held at college

Annai Velankanni's College of Arts & Science along with Magic Bus India Foundation organised a job fair at the college campus. According to a press release close to 50 reputed companies from various sectors took part.

Around 800 students, both under-graduation and post-graduation from various colleges, attended the fair and close to 500 candidates received appointment order, adds the release.

One-minute video contest for students

The Public Relations Society of India (PRSI), Chennai Chapter, in association with Coromandel International Limited, invites nominations for a state-level One-Minute Public Service Announcement (PSA) Video Contest on the theme "Save Food, Save Future."

The contest aims to inspire young filmmakers to use visual storytelling to promote food conservation and highlight the value of every grain produced through farmers' hard work. Open to college students, this initiative encourages youth participation in spreading awareness about responsible consumption and sustainability through impactful short-format cinema, said a release.

The contest will focus on the theme "Save Food, Save

Future" and the video must be produced in Tamil with a duration of exactly one minute. The last date for submission is April 14, 2026.

Winners will be awarded attractive cash prizes, with ₹25,000 for the first prize, ₹15,000 for the second prize, and ₹10,000 for the third prize.

The competition is open to college students between the ages of 17 and 24 who are studying in Tamil Nadu or Puducherry.

Entries will be evaluated by a panel of experts based on script and storytelling, direction, cinematography, production quality, and background music.

For further details, please contact: N. Raja, Secretary, Public Relations Society of India - Chennai Chapter, Mobile: 63838 53001

Two initiatives by doctors

A group of government and private doctors have launched two initiatives benefiting the public, 'GoingDoc-Doctors2Home, and 'Evening clinic @ your home'. GoingDoc offers consultations with a doctor and a staff nurse at your home from 5 to 9 pm for ₹ 499.

Evening clinic @ your home operates within a 5 km radius of Virugambakkam.

According to a press release, the doctors would visit the home for common illnesses such as colds, fevers, stomach pain, BP, and sugar. By using these initiatives, patients can avoid waiting in the clinic, travel time, and expenses. This will be helpful for children, working professionals, and senior citizens. Apart from the initiatives, they provide medicines, injections, IV fluids, and lab tests at a 10 percent discount.

For details, call or WhatsApp 73388 30305, 73388 30905.



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